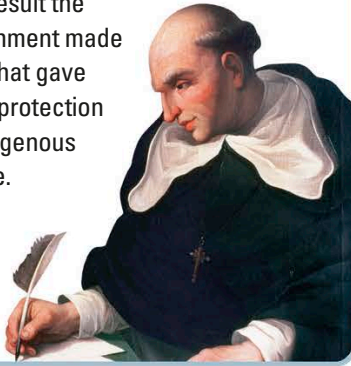


BARTOLOMÉ DE LAS CASAS

A Spanish missionary and historian, Bartolomé de las Casas (c. 1474–1566) was shocked at the cruel treatment of the Indigenous people by Spanish colonists. Determined to stop this exploitation, he documented it in a report to the Spanish king, Charles V. As a result the government made laws that gave some protection to Indigenous people.



▼ NEW DISEASES

Spanish invaders and settlers carried many new diseases, such as smallpox, influenza, measles, chickenpox, and typhus, that spread quickly among the Indigenous people of the Americas. Since they had no natural immunity to these diseases, many who got sick died. Almost 80 percent of the Aztec and Inca population died from such diseases, which allowed the Spanish to conquer the rest easily.



▲ ATAHUALPA

The last Inca emperor Atahualpa (reigned 1532–1533) was deeply respected by his people in Peru. In 1532, he agreed to hold an interview with Spanish conqueror Francisco Pizarro, at which the Spaniards launched an unexpected attack. Atahualpa was taken prisoner and later killed.

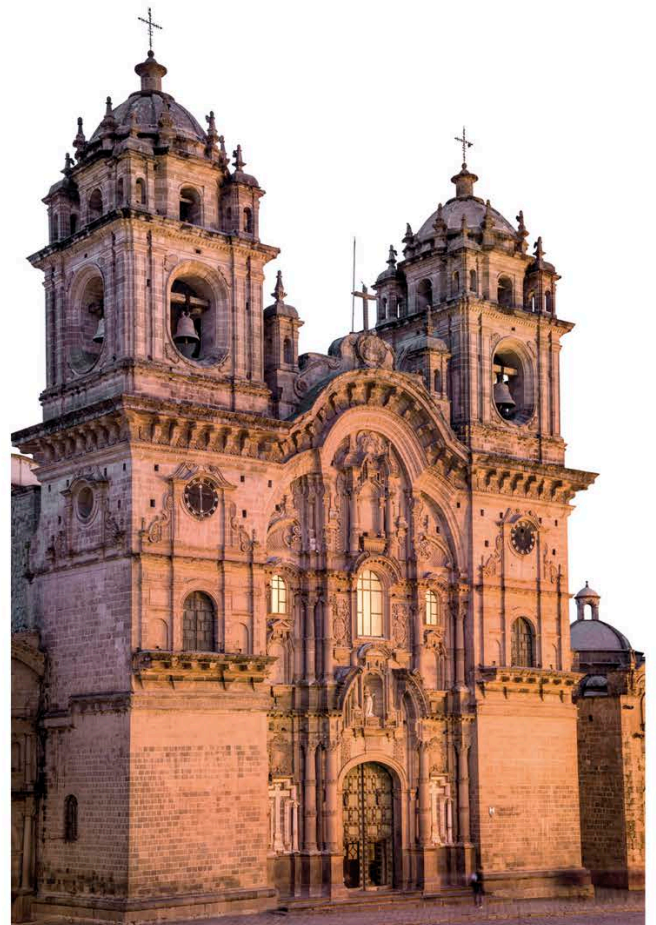


◀ SPANISH SILVER

Although the Spanish came seeking gold, they discovered the world's largest supply of silver in the mountains of Potosí (in modern-day Bolivia). Huge quantities of silver were taken to Spain to cover the cost of the country's wars in Europe. The silver from Potosí was used to mint Spanish dollar coins (left) called "pieces of eight."

▼ PORTUGAL AND BRAZIL

Portuguese explorer Pedro Álvares Cabral was on his way to India in 1500 when he accidentally found Brazil and claimed it for Portugal (see p.109). This marked the start of extensive colonization of Brazil by Portuguese settlers. In 1549, the city of Salvador (below) was established by the Portuguese as the first capital of Brazil.



▲ CHRISTIANITY

The colonization of the Americas involved bringing the native people into the fold of the Catholic Church. Indigenous practices and beliefs were not tolerated. Their temples were either destroyed or replaced with buildings such as this Jesuit church in Cuzco, Peru, built on top of an Inca ceremonial building.